

9-CONCEPT MATURITY TEST

Are You an AI User or an AI Builder?

The gap is measurable — I measured it.

10 tools · 4 real codebases · no dedicated test budget · 3 months

My QA Mapping: 9 Concepts, 5 Levels

L1 — AI Consumer

prompts only

L2 — Tool User

MCP

L3 — Builder

agentic loops, subagents

L4 — Target State

AI gateway, inference economics

L5 — Target State

evals, guardrails, observability

Core — all levels

context engineering

"My L1-L5 interpretation — not Barády's original scoring model."

Concept 2 — MCP

One interface to tools: email, repos, DB, browser

A CTO I work with runs paid Claude Code as his daily driver. MCP connected it to CI/CD, Slack, and Jira without extra integration setup.

"The tool was already there. The interface was the unlock."

Concepts 1 + 3 — Agentic Loops & Subagents

Plan → act → observe → reflect, until done · break big task → parallel → merge

Autonoma reached scenarioRecipe (step 4/6) but did not reach testGenerator — \$3.62 in run/API spend, 0 tests generated.

Planner → Generator → Healer fixed two stale snapshots in one session.

"The loop is the idea. The feedback loop is the product."

Concept 4 — AI Gateway

One control plane: auth, routing, rate limits, logs

3 switches

4 models · 1 session

No AI gateway was installed. deepseek → kimi → v4-pro → gpt-5.4-nano. Three switches across four models.

Concept 5 — Inference Economics

Every token costs money; caching cuts spend

\$3.62 vs \$0.19

Same Maintenance task — \$3.62 vs \$0.19 in run/API cost. Subscription fees and engineering time excluded.

"Know your cost per test, or you're flying blind."

L5 TARGET · QUALITY

Concepts 6 + 7 — Evals & Guardrails

Test outputs against benchmarks · filter unsafe input/output

34 / 34

34/34 mutation checks passed in the covered scope. This is an anti-overfit guardrail, not a full AI safety layer.

"Trust is measured, not assumed."

Concept 8 — Observability

Traces, logs, metrics for production AI

Allure provides test-run evidence. DORA provides delivery metrics. Model/tool telemetry is separate.

"Without it, 'passed' is a claim, not a fact."

CORE · ALL LEVELS

Concept 9 — Context Engineering

Feed the right context from retrieval, memory, tools

Fit the codebase into the window — not tokens into the codebase.

"The window is fixed. Your context strategy isn't."

VERDICT

The Tools Were Never the Bottleneck

The systems around them were.

Walk your stack against all 9 concepts · full article in comments · Which gate is missing: evals, cost controls, or context?